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Who Wrote Second Peter? Assessing Its Authorship, Dating, and Early Reception

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Who Wrote 2 Peter? Assessing Its Authorship, Dating, and Canon

The most controversial book within the NT canon is, without a doubt, 2 Peter. It has often been debated by scholars as to whether it was written by Peter or by someone either pretending to be him or using his authority (pseudepigrapha).[1] Even scholars such as Bruce Metzger doubted Peter wrote this epistle.[2] If Peter did not write it, then one might ask why it was included in the NT canon.[3] Did the Church Fathers make a mistake adding it to the canon?[4] In this paper, it is my objective to show that while the argument for Petrine authority is not without difficulties, it still seems that there is enough external evidence to suggest it is plausible that Peter *did* write 2 Peter and therefore should be part of the NT canon.

Importance of Authorship

To begin a discussion of 2 Peter, I must state why authorship matters for 2 Peter. Michael Kruger puts it succinctly: "There seems to be little dispute that apostolic authority was an essential criterion of canonicity for the early church."[5] The early church, therefore, accepted

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[1] I use the word "pretending" in substitute for "forger," which is what a pseudepigrapher is, so B. Ehrman, as noted in M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," *JETS* 42, no. 4 (December 1999): 645-71 (648). Ehrman states "'Indeed, despite its common occurrence, forgery was almost universally condemned by ancient authors.'" It may be said, then, that forgery was condemned in the early centuries and perhaps can be classified as a form of lying. The argument that a pseudepigrapher used Peter's name in order to write under Peter's authority is stated by T. Schreiner as the view of most scholars, see T. Schreiner *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, vol. 37 of *The New American Commentary* (Nashville: Broadman & Holman Publishers, 2003), 255.

[2] Stated by B. Ehrman in his blog, B. Ehrman, "A Writing of Peter that *Barely* Got Into the New Testament," *The Bart Ehrman Blog*, August, 2022, https://ehrmanblog.org/a-writing-of-peter-that-barely-got-into-the-new-testament/.

[3] This question is anticipated in K. Aland, "The Problem of Anonymity and Pseudonymity in Christian Literature of the First Two Centuries," *JTS* n.s. 12, no. 1 (April 1961): 39-49. Aland seemingly suggests that the reason some writings in the NT (ones that he supposes are pseudepigrapha) are included in the canon is not because they *were* written by their supposed author but because the early Christians *believed* they were written by them. See p. 49.

[4] So G. Klein and J. Dunn as noted in T. Schreiner, *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, vol. 37, 265. Schreiner writes, "[Klein] proceeds to say that it is unfortunate the letter was even included in the canon. Dunn remarks that some of the writings of Luther and Wesley are equal to, or even better than, what we find in 2 Peter." According to R. Wall in his work R. Wall, "The Canonical Function of 2 Peter," *NTS* 39, no. 4 (October 1993): 645-59, he states "A growing number of interpreters now read 2 Peter within the context of a wider body of pseudo-Petrine writings, all of which are deuteron-canonical and mostly heterodox." Thus, some modern critics treat 2 Peter's theology "in a manner similar to writings of the New Testament pseudepigrapha," 65. For a short discussion of some wishing to remove 2 Peter from the canon (or mark it as pseudepigrapha), see M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," 651-6.

[5] M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," 646-7. He also footnotes: "Bruce M. Metzger (*The New Testament: Its Background, Growth and Content* [New York: Abingdon, 1965] 276) declares that 'the chief criterion for

writings they believed came from those with apostolic authority, of which Peter was one.[6] The writings which claimed apostolic authority, while not being from an apostle (and therefore were considered pseudepigrapha), were often rejected.[7] This is the heart of the issue. If Peter did not write it, perhaps we ought to not accept it as Scripture![8]

Now, let us turn to the dating of the letter. R. Bauckham, in his commentary on Jude and 2 Peter, notes several factors that help us estimate when 2 Peter was written.[9] He identifies several connections, but I will point out two: (1) 2 Peter may have been an authoritative source for the *Apoc. Pet.* in the early second century, and (2) 2 Peter shares verbal similarities with the late first—and early second—century writings of *1 Clem.*, *2 Clem.*, and the *Shepherd of Hermas*.[10] He goes on to say that all four of these works may have been written in close proximity, "perhaps no more than twenty years" apart.[11] Takign into account other evidence, such as his interpretation of 3:4, he suggests that the dating is probably "c. AD 80-90," well after Peter's death.[12]

Michael Kruger largely agrees with Bauckham on dating.[13] Kruger turns to the early Church Fathers, noting that "Clement of Alexandria (c. 150-215)" wrote a now-lost commentary

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acceptance of particular writings as sacred, authoritative, and worthy of being read in services of worship was apostolic authorship.'"

[6] R. Bauckham disputes this claim in his work R. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, WBC 50 (Waco, TX: Word, 1983), 161-2, stating that the key in 2 Peter's authorship for the early church was not the writer but the "claim to be a faithful mediator of the apostolic message." Therefore, according to Bauckham, the message is more important than the author.

[7] See M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," 647. It is here that Kruger notes Serapion (c. AD 180) and his rejection of the *Gospel According to Peter*. Serapion wrote, "'We receive both Peter and the other apostles as Christ, but the writings which falsely bear their name (ψευδεπίγραφα[,that is, pseudepigrapha]) we reject.'"

[8] See footnotes 4, 6, and 7 for conflicting views.

[9] For much of what follows, I am indebted to R. Bauckham and his work found in *Jude, 2 Peter*, WBC 50.

[10] Ibid., 149-50. Bauckham suggests these dates for these works: *Apoc. Pet.* (perhaps c. AD 110-40), *1 Clem.* (c. AD 96), *2 Clem*. (perhaps end of first century, beginning of the second), and Hermas (c. AD 80-100). He states, "these three works are 2 Peter's closest relatives in the early church," 150.

[11] Ibid., 150.

[12] Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, 158.

[13] For much of what follows, I am indebted to M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," *JETS 42*, 645-71.

on 2 Peter.[14] "Irenaeus (c. 130-200)" may have also known the epistle.[15] Also, "Justin Martyr (c. 115-165)" may allude to 2 Peter 2:1 in his work *Dialogue with Trypho*.[16] In agreement with Bauckham, Kruger notes the possibility "that the *Apocalypse of Peter* (c. 110) was dependent upon 2 Peter."[17] Finally, Kruger pushes the date back into the first century with his notation of "1 Clement (c. 95-97)."[18] Where Kruger and Bauckham diverge is at 3:4. Bauckham interprets "the fathers" to mean the apostolic fathers (and the first generation of believers), thus signaling 2 Peter comes from a post-apostolic age.[19] By contrast, Kruger notes that this is not necessarily the correct interpretation because "nowhere in the NT or in the Apostolic Fathers is οἱ πατέρες [, the fathers,] used to refer to Christian 'Fathers,' but is consistently used to refer to Jewish patriarchs."[20] Thus, a fundamental piece of evidence in Bauckham's dating loses its power.[21] Bauckham also states that Jude (either a source *for* 2 Peter or a book which used 2 Peter *as* a source) may be dated to the AD 50s. If Bauckham is correct in saying that 2 Peter is connected with *1 Clem., 2 Clem.,* and the *Shepherd of Hermas* and that Jude was written in the AD 50s, but Kruger is right about how 3:4 ought to be interpreted, then we are no longer required to say that the book must be post-apostolic and therefore the claim of Petrine authorship has more plausibility than is often acknowledge.[22]

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[14] Ibid., 652.
[15] Ibid., 653.
[16] Ibid., 654.
[17] Ibid.
[18] Ibid.
[19] R. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, 158. Peter is believed to have died somewhere from AD 60-8. See T. Schreiner, *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, 276. Bauckham believes one can be confident it is "in AD 64 or 65." See R. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, 159.
[20] M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," 665.
[21] Bauckham admits that the interpretation of "Fathers" as OT fathers has "the weight of usage," R. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, 290.
[22] Ibid., 13. Bauckham's view restricts him to a window that is post-apostolic but pre-second century. However, if 3:4 is as Kruger states, the window may be more like AD 50-90.

Early Reception into the NT Canon

It must be stated that some in the early church doubted Petrine authorship. R. Bauckham writes, "Evidently 2 Peter was known throughout the second century, at least in some circles, but not widely used."[23] He states that the churches that had the letter may have known that Peter did not write it and consequently viewed it as being in the same category as the rest of the pseudo-Petrine works.[24] This could explain the lack of widespread circulation.[25] Bauckham concludes by stating that the letter was gradually accepted, and Jerome's firm stamp of approval probably helped its case.[26] Thus its attestation in the early church is clearly weak.

Kruger, as stated above, notes those who acknowledge its canonicity: Origen (c. AD 254; who used it, calling it Scripture, though he had some doubts about its authorship), Athanasius (c. AD 373), Gregory of Nazianzus (c. AD 390), Jerome (c. AD 420), and Augustine (c. AD 430).[27] Notably, Jerome believed that the different linguistic styles of 1 and 2 Peter were due to "different amanuenses" (i.e., different secretaries).[28] Kruger says, "After Jerome's time, there

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[23] Ibid., 163.
[24] Ibid.
[25] Ibid., 162-3.
[26] Ibid. 163.
[27] For the full discussion of 2 Peter and Church Fathers, see M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of Peter," 649-51. See also B. Warfield, "The Canonicity of Second Peter," *Southern Presbyterian Review* 33, no. 1 (January 1881): 45-75 (54-64). The dates of deaths are supplied by K. Aland in K. Aland et al., eds., *The Greek New Testament*, 3rd ed. (Stuttgart: United Bible Societies, 1975), xxxvii-ix. Here are the citations for each of these Church Fathers: Origen, *Homilies on Joshua*, Hom. 7.1, trans. Barbara J. Bruce, *Ancient Christian Writers* 71 (New York: Paulist Press, 2002), 74, https://books.google.com/books?id=Yq6reMY6KMUC&pg=PA74&source=gbs_toc_r&cad=1#v=onepage&q&f=false; Athanasius of Alexandria, "Festal Letter 39," *Early Church Texts*, accessed April 10, 2026, https://earlychurchtexts.com/public/athanasius_39th_festal_letter.htm; Gregory of Nazianzus, "Concerning the Genuine Books of Divinely Inspired Scripture," *Bible Research*, accessed April 10, 2026, https://www.bible-researcher.com/gregory.html; Jerome, *Epistula 120 (Ad Hedibiam)*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd ser., vol. 6, trans. W. H. Fremantle (New York: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1893), accessed April 9, 2026, https://www.tertullian.org/fathers/jerome_hedibia_2_trans.htm; and Augustine, *On the Spirit and the Letter (De spiritu et literra*), chap. 52. In *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers,* First Series, vol. 5. Translated by Peter Holmes and Robert Ernest Wallis. Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1887. New Advent, https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/1502.htm.
[28] Ibid., 650. For a discussion of the linguistic differences and similarities, see R. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, 143-7; and M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," 656-61. For Jerome's mention of two interpreters for 1 and 2 Peter, respectively, see Jerome, *Epistula 120 (Ad Hedibiam)*. It can be found under question #11.

were no further doubts concerning 2 Peter's place in the NT canon."[29] While 2 Peter is absent from some canonical lists such as "the Muratorian Fragment (c. 180)," Kruger says that this does not mean it was absent due to rejection.[30] The earliest papyrus containing 2 Peter is $\mathfrak{P}^{72}$ (found within the Miscellaneous Codex): c. AD 250-300.[31] Interestingly, this codex contains 1 and 2 Peter, Jude, Psalm 33 and 34 (LXX), and other books, thus suggesting a high view of 1 and 2 Peter.[32] It is also included in "Codex Sinaiticus (4th century), Codex Vaticanus (4th century), and Codex Alexandrinus (5th century)."[33] Ultimately, 2 Peter was accepted into the canon based on the belief that Peter wrote it.[34] Kruger makes a helpful point: the letter was accepted as Petrine despite its early controversy and the presence of pseudo-Petrine literature; and we ought to at the least acknowledge that this may be evidence that the letter is from Peter.[35]

Analysis and Conclusion

In my research, I found both sides of the argument for and against Petrine authorship to provide helpful information to the discussion. However, I found the pro-Petrine arguments sufficient to challenge the conclusion that Peter did not write it. From the dating of the letter, it seems that it was probably written in the first century, perhaps reaching early enough for Peter to

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[29] Ibid.
[30] Ibid.
[31] For a detailed discussion of the significance of this manuscript, see P. Strickland, "The Curious Case of $\mathfrak{P}^{72}$: What an Ancient Manuscript Can Tell Us about the Epistles of Peter and Jude," *JETS* 57, no. 4 (December 2014): 781-91. The dating is found on p. 784.
[32] Strickland, in ibid., states that, in addition to this Miscellaneous Codex, the community who had $\mathfrak{P}^{72}$ also had a "third century copy of 1 Peter, written in Sahidic Coptic" and "Psalms 33 and 34 were probably included in the Miscellaneous Codex because of the use of those psalms in 1 Peter…[and] the decision to include Melito's *Paschal Homily*…is probably largely due to Melito's literary dependence upon 1 Peter," 789. It appears, then, that the community who owned the Miscellaneous Codex may have seen the Petrine tradition, including 2 Peter, as *authoritative texts* in the middle third to beginning of the fourth century, the time during, or after, Origen's lifetime.
[33] M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," 651.
[34] T. Schreiner, *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, 264.
[35] M. Kruger, "The Authenticity of 2 Peter," 651. He also writes, "Is it so easy to dismiss the conclusions of Origen, Cyril of Jerusalem, Gregory Nazianzen, Ephiphanius, Athanasius, Augustine, Rufinus, Jerome, and the church councils of Laodicea, Hippo and Carthage?"

have been the author.[36] From the Church Fathers, it is clear that some questioned the letter but ultimately accepted it as coming from Peter. There is more to discuss, such as the internal evidence; however, based on the external evidence, it seems plausible to me that Peter wrote 2 Peter and that it therefore holds its rightful place in the NT canon right after 1 Peter, his first canonical letter.

[36] It is questionable whether Peter wrote the letter with his own hand or whether he used a secretary. Jerome believed Peter used a secretary. See *Epistula 120*; also, this view is suggested as "quite possible" by T. Schreiner, *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, 265. Some scholars, such as B. Ehrman, question whether Peter would have even been capable of writing the letter, supposing that he was illiterate. See B. Ehrman, "But Could Peter Write Anything?" *YouTube* video, 42:44, posted 2024, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PshpCo28UpE. For a counter discussion of ancient illiteracy, see P. Eddy and G. Boyd, *The Jesus Legend: A Case for the Historical Reliability of the Synoptic Jesus Tradition* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2007), 241-52 (249-50).

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